
“ONLINE TRAVEL REVIEWS” IN TOURISM

¹ Bindu, ² Indu and ³ Dr Ranbir Singh

^{1,2} (Research Scholar, Institute of Hotel and Tourism Management Maharshi Dayanand University, Rohtak, Haryana, India)

³ (Assistant Professor, Institute of Hotel and Tourism Management Maharshi Dayanand University, Rohtak, Haryana, India)

Abstract: The changing technologies and internet are playing a significant role in tourism and hospitality business. The travellers as well as the tourism service providers use the social networking sites on regular bases, especially Online Travel Reviews (OTR). OTR are written by the travellers who share their experiences, give suggestions or express satisfaction/dissatisfaction after product consumption. The objectives of this study are- 1) to examine the relevance of social networking sites and OTR in tourism, 2) to discuss relationship between the OTR & UGC and 3) to examine the present scenario of OTR in tourism business. Results indicate that reviews are helpful in potential travellers' decision makings especially at the planning phase. OTR are considered more effective to the potential tourists, in spite of the information given by travel service providers. Trustworthiness of OTR is the major problems faced by travellers. The hoteliers need to manage and respond to the reviews in an effective way. Consumers should be encouraged to post comments on the review sites. The tourism stockholders need to decide their e-commerce strategies for their betterment.

Keywords: Social Networking Sites, e-WOM, Online Travel Reviews, User Generated Sites, Future Trends

INTRODUCTION

Information technology have played important role in shaping a different way the tourists experience. Introduction to Computer Reservation System (CRS) in 1970, Global Distribution System (GDS) in 1980 and internet in 1990, dynamic packaging, multimedia, mobile technologies, and wearable technologies and smart tourism have witnessed some significant changes in tourism industry and have increased the possibilities for both the tourism service provides and the travellers (Baka, V.,2016). Buhalis & Law (2008) notified that the customer centric technologies will to be the centre of tourism in upcoming years. Around 1990, User Generated Contents (UGC) was first emerged (Shao, 2009). Xiang and Gretzel, (2010) depicted various forms of UGC for instance virtual communities (e.g., Lonely Planet), consumer reviews (e.g., Yelp), personal stand-alone blogs, blog aggregators (e.g., Live Journal) and microblogging platforms (e.g., Tumblr), social networks (e.g., Facebook), media sharing tools (e.g., Flickr, YouTube), and wikis (e.g., Wikitravel). The communication and information technology are closely associated with tourism due to its dynamic aspect. Internet acts as a major tool for marketing for the tourism service providers. It facilitates them to showcase their products and spread information to wide range of customers' worldwide (D. Buhalis, 1998). With the background, present paper is aimed to- 1) To assess the utility of social network sites for direct stakeholders of tourism industry, 2) To discuss the relationship between User Generated Content and Online Travel Reviews, 3) To examine the relevance of OTR in tourism, 4) To investigate the usage patterns of OTR among travellers and 5) To discuss the future of OTR in development of tourism business.

Utility of Social Networking Sites

eWOM have now replaced Word of Mouth (WOM). Web2.0 which is both read and write web act as a major platform for the consumers, where they can easily share their views regarding any service and product (S. De Ascaniis, U. Gretzel 2013). eWOM cover a number of media forms and various types of websites. The easy availability and easy operations of these social media websites motivates customers to use them. The information shared by the customers on these is termed as UGC and regarded as identical to eWOM (S. De Ascaniis et al, 2013). Chatterjee, (2001) describes consumer reviews and ratings as the easily available and widespread form of eWOM. The marketing practices have been changed by the services providers. Now a day social networking sites such as facebook, twitter, flicker, youtube these have become the major platforms where the marketers get in touch with the consumers and represent their products, news, and offers online (Baka, V., 2016). Most of the hotels have their own official websites where they post videos related to their property, show the photographs of different sections of hotels. They also provide the facilities to the customers from where they can do there bookings directly. Blogs have also become inspiring platform for them where these are written in an attractive manner. Thus the social networking sites have become a means of retaining the reliable consumers and act as a tool of creating consciousness and promotion. (Baka, V., 2016).

Online Travel Review and User Generated Reviews

In the area of online tourism-e-tourism, online reviews are considered widespread form of eWOM. Tourists post their opinions regarding any tourism related products or services. They share their travel related experiences or express dissatisfaction about them. Online travel reviews are meant to be posted without any monetary benefit for assisting the potential customers who are unknown to the reviewer (S. De Ascaniis et al, 2013). Online reviews are different from the other UGC available on social media in a number of ways. These can be shorter than the forum posts which are followed by the discussion and develop threads in form of communication. Online Travel Reviews are shorter than blogs, which is a form of diary. In OTR information is always one-way. But in forums and blogs readers usually can join in for the further communication (S. De Ascaniis et al, 2013). OTR can be easily differentiated from the other online platforms due to their detectable features (S. De Ascaniis et al, 2013). OTR are the experiences of tourists, integrated with assessment. Through reviews the reviewer wants to make others aware of what he had experienced and provide them intimation regarding the same. But bloggers have come up with a storytelling prospective, while describe their experience in a personal manner.

De Ascaniis, (2013) defines online travel reviews as “travel advice about a destination is given, in the form of a direct or indirect visit recommendation, by expressing an opinion on the destination. A constellation of arguments is put forward to support the opinion, which is based on a personal previous travel experience. Those aspects of the experience or the destination itself that are considered the most relevant are described, and suggestions are provided to help the reader to get the most from her trip. Narratives of the personal travel story and trip details constitute additional elements which contribute shaping prospective tourists’ expectations.”

As compared to information created by seller about the product, information created by customers is considered to be more consumers centric, while the former is describe the attributes of the products rather than information more useful for the consumers. (Chen, Y., & Xie, J., 2008). Researchers found that there is difference between Online Consumer reviews (OCR) and Online Travel Reviews (OTR) as the former is about an object which is consumed by the consumer and then post a review about the object but OTR are all about the experienced things (S. De Ascaniis et al, 2013). Litvin, S. W., Goldsmith, R. E., Pan, B. (2008) describe OCR as one to many communication as the reviewer once post his views on review sites which further assist the readers. OCR is the opinions of a potential, actual or former consumer which is shared in a unstructured format. It can be positive, negative or neutral. Consumer publish their views on the various available review sites accordingly such as an independent consumer review website (e.g. Trip Advisor.com), Third party commerce website (e.g. Booking.com), or corporate website (e.g. Thomson.co.uk).

Relevance of Online Travel Reviews in Tourism

According to Pew Internet & American Life Project (2005) in matter of online actions, searching for travel related information is very prominent. In Web 2.0 Online Travel Reviews is regard as more affective and useful. The actual tourists after visiting any destination, staying in hotels and availing any services of the tourism service providers post their views about the same on the review sites both in quantitative and qualitative forms e.g. ratings, subjectivity. These direct aids the potential travellers. There are many online travel agencies such as Expedia.io.uk, Holiday.com etc. where writing user generated reviews have become a common practise (Gretzel, Hyan-Yoo, & Purifoy, 2007). It has been observed that being commercial sites these are considered less reliable in comparison of the dedicated review sites such as Tripadvisor.com, yelp.com (Gretzel et al, 2007). In the travel field Trip Advisor.com is considered the most well-known stand-alone user generated review sites (Gretzel et al, 2007). Up to datedness, enjoyment and reliability are the key features of information which is available in the form of eWOM, in spite of the information given by travel service providers (Gretzel et al, 2007). In comparison of official tourism websites, online travel agencies or any other mass media promotion, UGC are considered more effective (Fotis, J., Buhalis, D., & Rossides, N. 2012). It is found that tourists prefer to use social media more for sharing their experiences after visiting destinations. Even the potential tourists’ decisions are greatly affected due to social media and they change plan accordingly. Tourists found peer reviews more effective and better. OTR are more useful to potential tourists at the starting phase of planning the tour (Gretzel, Hyan-Yoo, & Purifoy, 2007). OTR not only assist the potential tourists in information search but also aware them about new destinations, travel products/ services, provide suggestions regarding tour, give ideas, assist them in evaluating the available options, minimise any kind of doubt and help in building image of the destination and built confidence over their decisions (Gretzel et al, 2008).

Usage Patterns of Online Travel Reviews

Gretzel, U., & Yoo, K. H. (2008) conducted a study on OTR for which web-based survey was done. The researchers found that majority of people use internet and engage in a number of online activities such as reading blogs, rating reviews, video downloading, posting pictures on websites etc. (Gretzel et al, 2008). It was found that Tripadvisor.com users plan their trips in advance and mostly travel for pleasure and internet plays a big role in information search. The other tourists reviews, blogs, printing out maps, brochures etc. are the major



online sources potential tourists or they go through (Gretzel et al, 2008). More than half of the respondents read OTR each time they do planning for their tour (Gretzel et al, 2008). Virtual communities' websites are considered the most useable source of information followed by travel guidebooks, online travel agency, portal sites or any local websites (Gretzel et al, 2008). The reviews of actual travellers have proved to be great helpful for the potential tourists especially in choice of accommodation (Gretzel et al, 2008). The review readers evaluate any review on the base of its contents, the type of websites where the review is written as well as the date of the review posted (Gretzel et al, 2008). Travel experience of reviewer, intention for touring, tour activities are the major factors which effect the credibility of reviewer (Gretzel et al, 2008). It was found that most of the review readers also post reviews in order to assist the potential consumers, help the tourism service providers and even for outwardness. Neither review is posted for any kind of monetary benefit or for talking ill of anyone (Gretzel et al, 2008).

Online Travel Reviews: Present Scenario

In term of availability of huge data, speed, ease of data collection and its practical uses in comparison to the traditional methods and surveys online reviews are considered more effective. In the recent past few years the researchers are continuously using the social media big data being real time data for attaining their purposes of research. Due to advancement in technology the data available online act as a helpful mechanism for the tourism experts. It helps them in examining the factors which influence consumers for purchasing (Kwok, L., Xie, K. L., & Richards, T., 2017). In field of tourism and hospitality sector researchers have used UGC to explore the different aspects of service quality, destination image, reputation, experience and behaviour, importance of UGC as electronic word of mouth (eWOM) and tourists' mobility patterns. Further, it was found that specialized software was also used to handle and interpret the data (Lu, Stepchenkova, 2014). The studies focused on consumer were basically conducted to identify the using patterns of social media by potential customers and its effect while planning their tour. Further the studies which focused on suppliers' sides were based on marketing, research functions and management. While some other researchers also examined allocation of products and services. (Leung, D., Law, R., Van Hoof, H., & Buhalis, D., 2013).

KL Xie, Z Zhang, Z Zhang, (2014) found that the management response adversely affects the performance of hotel. It may be due to seeing the response tourists have a propensity to give more critique views. Sometimes the managers too fail to completely address or solve the problems presented by the consumer. The potential tourists take help of the review sites such as trip advisor, yelp, open rice etc. in order to take their decision regarding attractions, destinations, accommodations, and restaurants (Filieri, R., 2016). OCR have played important role in influencing the travel decisions of tourists and act as a mechanism of awareness and have affected their attitude towards hotels and product sales (Filieri & McLeay, 2014; Sparks & Browning, 2011, Vermeulen & Seegers, 2009, Ye, Law, & Gu, 2009). Bansky and Frame (2009) found that there is no specific instruction followed by the hotels or accommodation units for keeping an eye on and neither have they reacted to the OTR. Only a very few around 7% of hotels respond to the OTR while the consumers consider the response of manager very useful and important (Revinat, 2011). OCR helps in rapidly solving the arising functioning issues, which are shared by the actual consumers and this is possible only if the management keep scrutinizing these and adopt a real time approach. Hoteliers can do comparison with their competitors and check their market positions. By adopting strategies more affectively, they can set a favourable position in market (Molinillo, S., Ximénez-de-Sandoval, J. L., Fernández-Morales, A., & Coca-Stefaniak, A. 2016). It is one of the prime responsibilities of hospitality business to keep motivating the consumers for posting comments on their review websites. It can be done by providing facilities such as free Wi-Fi etc. so that they share their fresh views (Molinillo et al, 2016). It was found that in comparison of large hotels, smaller hotels give higher ratings. This may be due to timely managing the consumer messages and providing customised services (Molinillo et al, 2016).

In the recent years the number of online travel reviews is increasing dramatically. All are interested in having at top ranks and want favourable reviews. Such a case arise questions on the trustworthiness of the reviews, especially OTR where, everything is based on experience (Smith, 2013). The questions against the trustworthiness is raised seeing the rising number of fake reviews by the managers of their properties and few unethical practices like providing discount in exchange of favourable reviews. There is requirement of inspecting such promotional reviews.

High ratings and positive eWOM assist in settling the premium price for the accommodation units (Yacouel & Fleischer, 2012; Zhang, Ye, & Law, 2011). Ögüt and Onur Taş (2012) found that in tourism, sales enlarged when the online consumer ratings increased. Moreover increase in travel review rating directly improved online travel sales (Ye, Law, and Gu.2009, Ye et al. 2011). Reviews with high rating influence the businesses positively. Online reviews are useful for the service providers and customers. Suppliers use reviews in form of feedback of their products and services, while consumers read these for better decision making (Bissell, 2012; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). Online travel reviews play an important role in promoting, selling and



sustaining status of Hospitality and Tourism sector. The studies on the review encourage the managers in deciding their e-commerce strategies for the betterments. (Fang, B., Ye, Q., Kucukusta, D., & Law, R. 2016) (Liu, Park, 2015).

Online Travel Reviews: Future Perspective

Tim O'Reilly (2008), while explaining Web 2.0 says "We're just at the beginning of understanding how the social graph will change every web application... what is emerging is the identity and social subsystem of the future internet operating system." Due to the on-going changes in technology, information exchange and usages of internet the social media sites are not fully confident of their own future. The users of such sites as well as the researchers are concerned about the changing patterns and the effect of social networking sites (Loud house Research, 2007). In the language of tourism Philip C. Wolf changed the name of Web 2.0 applications to Travel 2.0 applications and these have brought a no of changes in the field of tourism. (Miguéns, J., Baggio, R., & Costa, C. 2008). Now consumers are well informed due to easy availability of sources on internet. They have got platforms where they post their opinions; provide suggestions to readers in an unstructured way. Such an atmosphere is not only helpful for the users but also assist the potential tourists in their purchase decisions. In the tourism sector UGC now a day are available in a number of forms such as online travel reviews, travel forum, travel wikis, travel blogs and many other networking sites (Baka, V. 2016). But till now it has been examined that there have been extensive research on eWOM, social networking sites but still eWOM effect on the reputation of any business is still little explored in details (Van Norel, N. D., Kommers, P. A. M., Van Hoof, J. J., & Verhoeven, J. W. M., 2014). The researchers have focused a little on managing WOM by the service providers (William and Buttle, 2011). Now there is requirement of adding new research prospective using different theories and adapting new methodologies. In these social networking sites the reviews, recommendations, stories etc. Form an image of the products/ services for the users that can be challenging for the service providers to understand and act accordingly (Baka, V. & Scott, S.V., 2009).

CONCLUSION

Tourism is widely affected due to the emergence of Web 2.0 and Travel 2.0. (Miguéns, J., Baggio, R., & Costa, C., 2008). Now the social networking sites are not just a means of communication but acts as multi task performer for the tourism stakeholders. OTR are in many ways different from other UGC e.g. travel wikis, blogs, forums etc. The opinions, comments, and views of actual consumer on social networking sites especially OTR is considered to be more effective and trustworthy regardless of the marketing done by the services providers through brochures, photographs, advertisements (O'Connor, P. (2008). Users of review sites plan their tours in advance and take decisions regarding destination, hotels or other services with the help of other reviews. The review sites assist in promoting, selling and maintaining tourism business. There is need of affectively managing the reviews by the stakeholders and considering the changes in information technology.

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